

ASTRAVERSE
CREATOR
Ayan Mukerji

Brahmastra: Part One - Shiva (2022)

Coming up: Parts II and III in 2026 and 2027, respectively

speak to you", noted Vijan. The moment characters from differing worlds meet, he said, "should be a surprise but not the highlight. The film needs to work on its own and gel with the larger theme."

For Ayan Mukerji, creating Astraverse, which began with *Brahmastra: Part One-Shiva* (2022), is akin to "writing my own books". He spent nine years developing Astraverse, which is heavily inspired by Hindu gods and goddesses. "Sometimes, when you do big things in life, you jump into them without knowing what you're getting into," he told INDIA TODAY last year. "I was so enamoured by what I wanted to create, I didn't have a roadmap and didn't know what to expect. I've believed through all these years that this could be my *Star Wars* moment where I'll create something that's an achievement in Indian cinema." The more time Mukerji spent etching his characters and adding flourishes, the more convinced he was that he was onto something unique.

Mukerji already has the spine for parts II and III ready. He recently said that he will shoot the two parts together and have them in cinemas by December 2026 and 2027, respectively. With a deal reportedly in place with a big studio, he hopes to expand Astraverse with spin-offs and animated series for both OTT and cinemas. Maddock's horror comedy universe, too, is shaping up on money from Jio Studios.



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Creator of Astraverse

Vijan sees some exciting times ahead. Confessing that he is scared of horror films himself, the horror comedy genre allowed him to pepper the scares with some laughs. The success of *Stree* gave him the confidence to imagine a whole universe. "We looked within and found so many stories and folklore within our culture that naturally lent themselves to the genre," he says. After *Stree* came *Roohi* in 2021, but it was with last year's *Bhediya* that the universe began taking shape. Rajkummar Rao and Aparshakti Khurana reprised their *Stree* characters to make a late entry in *Bhediya*. Recently, Vijan confirmed sequels for both films as well as the introduction of more characters with standalone films. "It is going to happen organically," he said. "Every character stands for something and has been affected by something. We are leaving breadcrumbs that can be picked up to make something new altogether." May the force be with this tribe. ■